

NAPCS Unionization Research — State — Charter Sector Overview

Iowa — Dual jurisdiction: NLRB R33 (Track A) / Iowa PERA Iowa Code §20 (Track B)

Jurisdiction — June 6, 2026

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Section 1: State Overview

State	Iowa
Labor Board	Dual jurisdiction: NLRB R33 (Track A) / Iowa PERA Iowa Code §20 (Track B) — Track A (independently incorporated): National Labor Relations Board — Region 33, Peoria, Illinois. Track B (School Board Model): Iowa Employment Appeals Board (EAB, formerly PERB) administers Iowa PERA for district employees.
Governing Law	DUAL TRACK. Track A: National Labor Relations Act (NLRA) — Iowa Code §256E independently incorporated charter schools are private employers under NLRB R33. Track B: Iowa PERA (Iowa Code §20) — School Board Model (CSD*) charter school teachers are employees of the authorizing school district. Iowa school districts are public employers under Iowa Code §20.3. ISEA/NEA affiliates hold teacher agreements at virtually all Iowa districts. District teacher agreements cover CSD* charter school teachers by virtue of district employment.
Federal NLRB Jurisdiction	YES — NLRB R33 (Peoria) applies to Track A independently incorporated charter schools only. Track B School Board Model schools are covered by Iowa PERA, not NLRB.
Right-to-Work	Right-to-Work State — Iowa Code Ch. 731 (Iowa Right to Work Act) (Iowa has been right-to-work since 1947. Applies to Track A schools. Track B schools are public employers under Iowa PERA — RTW does not apply in the same way but Iowa PERA was significantly restricted in 2017 (mandatory subjects of bargaining limited to base wages only).)
For-Profit Operator Status	For-profit EMO management contracts permitted under state law
Card-Check Available	NO — Iowa is right-to-work (Iowa Code Ch. 731). Track A: NLRB jurisdiction — secret ballot election required. Track B: Iowa PERA — district-level teacher agreement, no school-specific election.
Registry Sweep	COMPLETE — June 2026 — 10 charter schools searched
Research Window	June 2026

Section 2: Charter Sector Landscape

Total charter schools in Iowa: 10 (Iowa Department of Education Authorized Charter Schools List (March 2026), educate.iowa.gov. 10 currently open schools: 3 School Board Model (CSD*) + 7 independently incorporated. 5 additional schools authorized but not yet open (2 CSD* models + 3 independent) — excluded from research universe per PDR-013 zero-organized state protocol.). Unionization census figures reflect confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

Category	Schools	% of Total	Notes
DEPENDENT — Iowa PERA (School Board Model)	3	30% of universe	Hamburg Charter HS (Hamburg CSD), Storm Lake/Iowa Central/BVU Early College HS (Storm Lake CSD), West Central Charter HS (West Central CSD). District employment → Iowa PERA → ISEA/NEA teacher agreement coverage.
No Organizing Activity Documented (Track A)	7	70% of universe	All 7 independently incorporated IA charter schools. NLRB R33. RTW state. Young sector (2022–2025 openings). Zero NLRB petitions.

TOTAL	10	100%	
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Charter Sector Enrollment

Total Charter Enrollment	804 students — 0.2% of state K–12 enrollment (504,292 total K–12 students)
Students in CMO/EMO-Affiliated Charter Schools	150 students in network-affiliated schools — 18.7% of total charter enrollment
Students in Organized Charter Schools	0 students documented
Data Sources	Charter enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 / Charter School Registry v133. Total K–12 state enrollment: NCES ELSI 2024–25 (all public schools). Both figures from the same source and year.

Section 3: Charter Management Organizations & Education Management Organizations

Charter Management Organizations (CMOs) are nonprofit networks. Education Management Organizations (EMOs) are for-profit management companies. Data sourced from Charter School Registry v133. Union penetration reflects confirmed organized schools as of the data currency date.

CMO / EMO Name	Type	State Campuses	National Campuses †	Organized in State	Total Enrollment
Concept Schools	Network‡	1	—	—	150
TOTAL — All CMO/EMO Schools in Iowa		1		0 organized schools in network-affiliated charters	

† National Campuses reflects total campuses operated by this network across all states, as reported in Charter School Registry v133. Provides context for networks operating in multiple states.

‡ Network (type unclassified) = operator present in Charter School Registry v133 but not yet classified in CMO Reference data. Contact registry project to add classification for these records.

1 network (type unclassified). Approximately 9 schools operate independently with no CMO/EMO affiliation. Source: Charter School Registry v133.

Section 4: Legal Framework & Sector Overview

Findings are based on research as of June 6, 2026.

1: Legal & Jurisdictional Framework

DUAL TRACK. Track A: National Labor Relations Act (NLRA) — Iowa Code §256E independently incorporated charter schools are private employers under NLRB R33. Track B: Iowa PERA (Iowa Code §20) — School Board Model (CSD*) charter school teachers are employees of the authorizing school district. Iowa school districts are public employers under Iowa Code §20.3. ISEA/NEA affiliates hold teacher agreements at virtually all Iowa districts. District teacher agreements cover CSD* charter school teachers by virtue of district employment. Iowa is a right-to-work state (Iowa Code Ch. 731 (Iowa Right to Work Act)). Charter schools in Iowa are subject to NLRB jurisdiction as private employers (Dual jurisdiction: NLRB R33 (Track A) / Iowa PERA Iowa Code §20 (Track B)). Secret ballot NLRB election is the required organizing pathway. Card-check is not available.

2: Charter Sector Structure

Iowa operates 10 open-enrollment charter schools, enrolling approximately 804 students. 1 charter management organizations and education management organizations operate in Iowa. The largest networks by campus count are Concept Schools (1 campuses in state). Approximately 9 schools operate independently with no CMO or EMO affiliation. Network-level detail, including campus counts and total enrollment, appears in Section 3 above.

Section 5: Media Coverage & Public Stakeholder Positions

Media coverage and stakeholder position data not yet documented for this state.

Section 6: Contract & CBA Access Registry

Track B (School Board Model) schools are covered by their authorizing district teacher agreements under Iowa PERA. CBA links for each district are noted below. Track A schools have no CBA — no independently organized Iowa charter school exists.

Dual jurisdiction: NLRB R33 (Track A) / Iowa PERA Iowa Code §20 (Track B) public contracts portal. Direct PDF links may require a records request for full text.

School / Network	Union	CBA Status & Term	Contract Access
Hamburg Charter High School			N/A
Storm Lake/Iowa Central/BVU Early College High School			N/A
West Central Charter High School			N/A